

PRISONERS OF HOPE

TEXT: Zechariah 9:12 *“Return to the stronghold, you prisoners of hope. Even today I declare I will restore double to you.”*

INTRO: To be imprisoned is to be constrained under the authority of another. The people to whom Zechariah is preaching had been prisoners, living in exile in Babylon. They had, in the previous couple of years, returned to Israel.

The people were not happy; things had not worked out as well as they thought they would, nor as quickly as they thought possible.

They came back into the land with a slave mentality thinking things would be instantly better.

I want to ask us three questions about Hope today:

DO WE HAVE HOPE OR DOES HOPE HAVE US?

Things rarely change unless, and until our way of thinking changes:

- Lottery winners are often broke, very quickly...
- People who inherit large amounts of money rarely turn it into generational wealth...
- People who lose large amounts of weight quickly put more weight on, than they began with...

Why is this? Because things are powerless to change our lives until we have a mindset change.

The prophet Zechariah is warning these people not to be limited by the, “*Dreamed for*” outcomes they created in their minds, during the years of waiting to be freed, and sent back to the Promised Land.

Nothing is ever really what we dreamed it would be. Every single thing in life comes with its own challenges:

- Education comes with challenges...
- A career comes with challenges...
- Marriage comes with challenges...
- Parenting comes with challenges...
- Retirement comes with challenges...
- Living a Godly life comes with challenges...

No matter what we face, if Hope has us, rather than us having Hope, we can make it through the storm.

WHAT DOES IT REALLY MEAN TO BE A PRISONER OF HOPE?

The writer is reminding these people that God holds the future, and that they need to trust that He has something in store for them. They needed to let go of what they had envisioned it might look like, and let God show them the Hope filled future He had planned for them.

Remember, it is not about what we imagined it would be, but what God planned for it to be.

“Gods ways are higher than our ways.” Just when we think we have God figured out; He throws us a curve ball.

God wanted His people to return to the place where their boundaries were set by Hope – and Hope alone.

So, the prophet Zechariah was sent with a reminder to God’s people to center their Hope in their relationship with God. They were not to be Prisoners WITH Hope, but Prisoners OF Hope!

There is a BIG difference of being a Prisoner with Hope and being a Prisoner of Hope! As a Prisoner with Hope – We are trying to hold onto Hope for dear life! As a Prisoner of Hope, Hope has us!

WILL WE RECEIVE THE INVITATION OF THE LORD TO BECOME A PRISONER OF HOPE?

Did you notice that this is an invitation by God to be imprisoned? Being a Prisoner of Hope is a self-imposed condition. We choose it.

We should turn ourselves in today, to be imprisoned by God, where our boundaries are set by Hope.

In prison one has fixed boundaries and set rules. When one is a prisoner, every minute is planned for them. The only decision we have to make is whether or not to submit.

One thing is for certain... We are prisoners in this world. We didn't decide to come to this earth, we were assigned and confined to this world. We will either be a prisoner of despair or a Prisoner of Hope. Instead of being a prisoner of despair, we should choose to be Prisoners of Hope.

Instead of being confined by bitterness, resentment, or fear, we choose to be confined by Hope. As Prisoners of Hope we are confined to a specified area with fixed boundaries. A set of rules that are set and determined by Hope.

Being a Prisoner of Hope is a confinement of confidence in the goodness of God.

CONCLUSION:

Zechariah 9:12 “Return to the stronghold, you prisoners of hope. Even today I declare I will restore double to you.” The word “***Stronghold***” as it is used here, is “*Fortress.*”

If we are being harassed by the enemy, all we have to do is run back into the stronghold whose name is Jesus!

- Hope sets the direction of our lives...
- Hope holds us in the storms of life...
- Hope redeems us to our original purpose...
- Hope reverses the curse of the enemy...

- Hope gives us double for our trouble...